

CORE FORMULA

Hear the content -> make one relevant comment -> ask one question -> stop and listen. -> Short form: notice -> name or respond -> invite -> calibrate -> release. -> "That sounds like a big shift. What made you decide?" -> "That's a lot to weigh up. Which part mattered most?" -> "Sounds like it came after some thought. What tipped it?"

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Say one honest comment, then ask one clean question: "That sounds like a big shift. What made you decide?"

BEST FOR

- Meeting someone new
- Following up on a story
- Professional discovery without sounding like a checklist
- Digital messages where a bare question feels abrupt
- Interviews or supervision where you need specifics
- Softening a pointed or sensitive question

PHRASE BANK

Quick openers · Short comment + question

- "That's a big shift. What changed?"
- "Makes sense. What tipped it?"
- "Big call. How come?"
- "That's interesting. Why that one?"
- "Sounds full-on. What was the hardest part?"
- "That's a lot. What happened next?"
- "Fair enough. What made it click?"
- "Nice. What got you into it?"

Social & rapport · Warm reactions in casual chat

- "That sounds like a big shift. What changed for you?"
- "That's a strange spot to be in. How did you handle it?"
- "I can see why that stuck with you. What happened next?"
- "That sounds like it mattered. What made it feel that way?"
- "You lit up talking about that. What do you love about it?"
- "That sounds like a lot to sit with. What was the best part?"
- "I like that you went for it. What made you take the leap?"
- "That's a good story. What's the bit you usually leave out?"

Work & discovery · Meetings, clients, supervision

- "That's useful context. What was the main constraint?"
- "That sounds like a major transition. What drove it?"
- "That's a meaningful trade-off. How did you land on it?"
- "That's a helpful way to frame it. What would good look like from here?"
- "Sounds like the timeline was the pressure. What gave first?"
- "That's a fair concern. What would need to change to fix it?"
- "That's a big call for the team. What was the deciding factor?"

- "Good to know the history. What's the part you'd do differently?"

Getting to the specifics · Comment, then a clear ask

- "That's the crux of it. What exactly are you asking me to decide?"
- "That's clear enough. What do you need from me, and by when?"
- "That's a big claim. What's the evidence you're leaning on?"
- "Fair point. What specifically would you change first?"
- "That matters. What's the one thing that has to be true for this to work?"
- "Understood. Which option are you actually leaning towards?"
- "That's the sticking point. What's stopping you deciding today?"
- "Right, that's the real issue. What outcome do you want here?"

Softening & sensitive ground · Acknowledge before you ask

- "That sounds like it wasn't easy to talk about. Can I ask what the turning point was?"
- "I don't want to poke a sore spot. Is it okay to ask what happened?"
- "That clearly landed hard. What did you need at the time?"
- "I might be reading this wrong. What did you actually mean by that?"
- "That came out blunter than I intended. What's the part I'm missing?"
- "No pressure at all. If you're up for it, what changed things?"
- "I can tell this is delicate. Where would you rather I didn't push?"
- "Take your time. What feels most important for me to understand?"

Conflict & pressure · Neutral observation, then impact

- "I can see this really frustrated you. What did it cost you on your end?"
- "That clearly hit a nerve. What would make this feel fairer to you?"
- "We're both wound up. What's the thing you most need me to get?"
- "This has been sitting between us a while. What do you want to be different?"
- "I hear how serious this is for you. What's the impact I'm not seeing?"
- "That's a strong reaction, and probably a fair one. What set it off?"
- "Something in that clearly stung. What crossed a line for you?"
- "I don't want to make this worse. What would actually help right now?"

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

- Weak: Why did you do that? (A bare question can sound cross-examining.)
Better: That's a big choice. Why did you do it? (Adds context, but still slightly blunt.)
Best: That's a big choice. What made it feel like the right move? (Warmer and easier to answer.)
- Weak: What's the budget? (Lands as a demand.)
Better: Budgets are always tight on these. What's the budget? (Softer, but generic.)
Best: Budget's usually the hard part of these. Where does it need to land for this to work? (Invites the real answer.)
- Weak: Are you okay? (Easy to bat away with 'fine'.)
Better: You seem a bit off. Are you okay? (Names it, but still yes/no.)
Best: You've gone quiet since that meeting. What's sitting with you? (Specific, and opens a door.)

DECISION TREE

If You're about to ask a question

Add one true comment first — unless urgency demands a direct answer.

""That's a big shift. What made you decide?""

If The comment would be fake

Skip it and ask the question plainly. A false comment is worse than none.

""Can I ask what changed?""

If You've already asked a question

Don't stack another. Wait until they've finished answering.

If They gave a short, closed answer

Lower the pressure or change direction — don't push harder.

""No need to get into it. I was just curious.""

If It's a tense or emotional moment

Keep the comment neutral and ask about impact, not motive.

""I can see it mattered. What did you need at the time?""

If They corrected your frame

Take the correction, drop the technique, and just follow them.

""Fair enough — say more.""

SCENARIOS

First date or social chat

React briefly to their story before asking about it, so it reads as interest, not vetting. — *""That's a great way to spend a weekend. What got you into it?""*

Interview or supervision

Signal you followed their point before asking for specifics. — *""That's a useful bit of context. What was the constraint you were working around?""*

Text or DM

Add one contextual sentence so a bare question doesn't read as abrupt. — *""That's a lot to land in one week. What was the hardest part?""*

Conflict or tension

Offer a neutral observation before asking about impact — keep any judgement out of the comment. — *""I can see this really got to you. What did it cost you on your side?""*

Networking

Validate the interest before asking how, so it doesn't feel transactional. — *""That sounds like a genuinely hard problem to work on. How did you get into it?""*

Catching up with a friend

Name the shift you heard before asking them to unpack it. — *""That's a big change since we last spoke. How are you actually finding it?""*

WHEN NOT TO USE

- The situation needs a direct, urgent answer
- The comment would be fake
- You are already stacking several questions
- They have asked for a concise, straight answer
- Physical safety or an emergency takes priority

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the moments

Through today, catch three times someone shared something you could have reacted to before asking a question. Jot each one down — you're only training your eye for the cue.

Day 2 — Write the minimum move

For each of yesterday's three moments, write the shortest honest comment plus one clean question you could have said.

Day 3 — Weak -> better -> best

Take one bare question you ask often. Write it three ways: weak (bare), better (add context), best (warm and easy to answer).

Day 4 — Say it, then shorten it

Say your best lines aloud twice, then cut each by about a third until only the true part is left.

Day 5 — One live rep

In a low-stakes conversation, use the move once — one comment, one question — then stop and listen. Note what the person did next.

Day 6 — Calibrate

Use it two or three times today. For each, record whether they expanded, corrected, softened, shortened or redirected.

Day 7 — Recover on purpose

Let one question come out too blunt on purpose, then use a recovery line — "That came out more like an interview than I meant" — and notice how the moment resets.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I catch the right moment to comment, or force one?
- Was my comment true, or just padding to soften the question?
- Did I keep it to one comment and one question?
- Did I leave their autonomy intact — no disguised judgement or pressure?
- Did I stop after one move instead of overusing it?
- Did the exchange feel easier, or more self-conscious?